

Amendment to 'A Safe Bet' Ethics Application ETH2122-0810

CONTEXT AND RATIONALE

This amendment addresses necessary changes to the Netherlands site (Holland Casino) of the A Safe Bet project in response to the October 2024 Netherlands Gaming Authority (KSA) regulatory requirements.

As of October 1st 2024, the KSA introduced new regulatory requirements for online gambling operators, fundamentally altering the landscape for responsible gambling research. These measures mandate standardized Responsible Gambling (RG) tools across all players, creating significant challenges for the original design of the *A Safe Bet* Proof of Concept (POC). This amendment addresses necessary changes to the implementation of the POC study of the *A Safe Bet* project in response to these requirements.

The KSA regulations prioritize compliance and uniformity through mandatory player protection measures. This standardized approach directly conflicts with the original *A Safe Bet* POC design, which focused on:

- Tailored RG tools based on player risk levels
- Randomized deployment of RG tools
- Monthly dynamic adjustment of RG tools

Despite extensive efforts to preserve the original POC framework within these new regulatory constraints, several critical challenges emerged:

1. Technical Implementation Barriers

- Regulatory compliance updates for Holland Casino demanded full development capacity from technical services
- No remaining capacity for re-development & implementation POC RG tools/interventions
- High risk of system instability if POC framework was layered over mandatory tools
- Potential for operational failures in critical player protection systems

2. Regulatory Compliance Risks

- Fundamental incompatibility between tailoring of RG tools and standardized regulatory mandates
- Legal uncertainty surrounding the implementation of research tools alongside mandatory tools
- Unacceptable risk of regulatory violations
- Potential compromise of operator licensing requirements

3. Participant Experience Concerns

- Risk of overwhelming participants with dual intervention systems
- High likelihood of player confusion between research and regulatory tools

- Potential for participant frustration leading to disengagement
- Compromise of both participant protection and study integrity
- Risk of reduced effectiveness of mandatory protective measures

PROPOSED SOLUTION & SCIENTIFIC FRAMEWORK

This amendment proposes a transition of the original POC version of the RG framework for Netherlands to a "Dummy" POC model, establishing a critical foundation for the *A Safe Bet* project's long-term research objectives. This adaptation preserves both research integrity and participant protection while serving three primary functions:

1. **Baseline Data Foundation:** The POC's primary role is establishing comprehensive baseline data, fundamental to the project's scientific validity. This serves to:
 - Provide the control period necessary for the Beta phase's Interrupted Time-Series design
 - Create a standardized reference point for understanding player behavior under regulatory tools
 - Ensure scientific rigor through clear pre-intervention behavioral patterns
 - Maintain compatibility with other jurisdictions' datasets while adhering to local requirements
2. **Research Continuity and Participant Engagement:** The framework focuses on building and maintaining a consistent participant base, crucial for research validity and future development. This approach:
 - Ensures cohort continuity across study phases, enabling reliable longitudinal analysis
 - Familiarizes participants with research processes, reducing future attrition
 - Provides continuous behavioral data for long-term pattern analysis
 - Creates the foundation for testing future adaptive interventions
 - Maintains scientific connection between baseline observations and future studies
3. **Research Scope Definition:** To maintain scientific integrity, the Dummy POC explicitly excludes:
 - Evaluation of regulatory tool effectiveness or harm prevention
 - Analysis of player engagement patterns with mandatory tools
 - Assessment of RG framework feasibility or implementation success
 - Comparison of behavioral outcomes across player groups
 - Any analysis of the Dutch regulatory system's impact

This framework ensures the Dummy POC serves as more than a regulatory compliance measure - it provides the scientific foundation necessary for meaningful research progression in the Netherlands market.

OVERVIEW OF PROPOSED AMENDMENTS

1. STUDY FRAMEWORK MODIFICATIONS

- Transition from dynamic RG tools to standardized KSA mandatory tools (€300/€700 deposit limits)
- Single standardized implementation for all participants
- Retention of scheduled breaks feature only

2. COMMUNICATION PROTOCOL REVISIONS

- Enhanced mandatory warning messages
- Updated player information resources
- Standardized monthly communications

3. METHODOLOGICAL ADJUSTMENTS

- Shift from evaluating adaptive RG tools to baseline data collection
- Daily BetBuddy monitoring for player behavior and risk assessment
- Tracking of player engagement with mandatory tools
- Continued qualitative research (interviews and surveys) with focus on standardized tools
- Maintained sample size (12,900) and study period (Feb-July 2025)
- Unchanged inclusion criteria and enrollment procedures

DETAILED AMENDMENT SPECIFICATIONS

1. STUDY FRAMEWORK SPECIFICATIONS

The regulatory changes introduced by the KSA necessitate a complete redesign of the study framework for the Netherlands site. The original POC utilized dynamic monthly deployment of tailored RG tools based on player risk levels. The revised framework implements standardized requirements through the following specifications:

1.1 Implementation of Mandatory Regulatory Tools

- 1.1.1 All participants will receive only the mandatory RG tools as specified in KSA regulations (reference: [Responsible Gaming Policy Rule 2024](#))
- 1.1.2 All A Safe Bet POC add-on RG tools have been deactivated - Mandatory tools include enforced net deposit limits: €300 per month (young adults under 25) and €700 per month (general players)
- 1.1.3 All limits operate on a calendar month basis with automatic deposit blocking - Changes require affordability checks and customer service approval. Net deposit calculations operate in real-time, subtracting withdrawals from deposits
- 1.1.4 Mandatory login and playtime controls enforce automatic logouts at maximum playtime and standardized cool-off periods
- 1.1.5 Players receive mandatory warning messages at both 50% and 100% of their limits, with risk warnings and limit adjustment instructions

- 1.2 Standardization Protocol:** The original POC design involved dynamic deployment and configuration of RG tools based on player risk levels. Under the revised framework, this variable approach is removed entirely. There is no randomization, risk-based selection, or dynamic configuration during the study period. Instead, mandatory tools are implemented with identical settings across all participants, ensuring regulatory compliance while maintaining system stability and consistent player experience.
- 1.3 Retention of Supplementary Feature:** The scheduled breaks feature remains as the only non-regulatory tool, providing players the option to set pre-defined gambling break periods. This feature, already part of Holland Casino's RG policy, offers a low-friction addition that complements the mandatory framework without adding complexity.

2. COMMUNICATION PROTOCOL SPECIFICATIONS

The participant communication framework has been revised to align with KSA regulatory requirements while maintaining the core POC communication principles. The standardized protocol encompasses three key components:

- 2.1 Enhancement of Regulatory Messaging:** KSA regulations mandate specific notifications for RG tool interactions (including fixed warnings at 50% and 100% of limit thresholds). These mandatory messages are enhanced with clear, engaging language that emphasizes protection and empowerment. Unlike the original POC's risk-based approach, these communications are standardized across all participants.
- 2.2 Information Resource Updates:** Two key player resources remain operational with revised content:
- 2.2.1** The "Player Limits Explained" page focuses on mandatory RG tools, providing clear explanations of deposit limits, logout mechanisms, and tool functionality through an accessible format
 - 2.2.2** The "A Safe Bet Project Page" continues to serve as the central information hub, focusing on the project's scope of measuring player engagement with RG tools and communication framework, while maintaining our commitment to transparent data handling and participant protection

2.3 Monthly Engagement Protocol: Despite removing risk-based tool deployment, we maintain regular participant engagement through the intended monthly refresh messages. These standardized communications will be updated to focus on awareness of mandatory RG tools, highlight their protective benefits, and reinforce participants' valuable role in the study. While no longer tailored, these messages maintain our project's supportive tone and commitment to participant engagement.

3. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY SPECIFICATIONS

The Dummy POC shifts from evaluating adaptive RG tools to establishing a comprehensive baseline dataset of player behavior under standardized regulatory measures (i.e., "the

status quo”). This revised framework maintains the original mixed-methods research approach while adapting its purpose.

- 3.1 **Quantitative Data Collection:** The BetBuddy algorithm continues daily player monitoring, now focused on establishing baseline behavioral patterns rather than informing intervention deployment. Data collection encompasses daily gambling metrics, risk level transitions, and tool interactions under the mandatory regulatory framework. These measurements are aggregated monthly to provide longitudinal behavioral insights and risk assessments. These metrics establish the baseline dataset essential for comparative analysis in the project’s future Alpha and Beta phases.
- 3.2 **Engagement Monitoring Protocol:** Comprehensive tracking of player interactions with mandatory RG tools continues, including response rates to notifications, tool usage patterns, and limit adjustment requests. This systematic monitoring provides insights into player engagement with standardized protective measures, informing future project phases while maintaining regulatory compliance.
- 3.3 **Qualitative Assessment:** The participant interview schedule continues, now examining experiences with standardized RG tools rather than the original adaptive framework. User satisfaction surveys maintain their original format and deployment schedule, with revised focus on interactions with mandatory tools.
- 3.4 **Sample Specifications:** The study maintains its original target sample size of 12,900 players and six-month duration period (February - July 2025) to ensure comparable data collection.
- 3.5 **Inclusion Parameters:** Inclusion criteria, enrollment procedures, and consent strategy remain unchanged from the original ethics application. Participants must meet established activity thresholds for study qualification, with risk level categorization continuing through our established frequency-based scoring method.
- 3.6 **Enrollment Protocol:** Participants receive an updated version of the non-dismissible notification about the study and data collection with the EUR at enrollment. Consent remains embedded within operator privacy statements, with continued access to study information through dedicated website pages.

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS AND SAFEGUARDS

The implementation of the revised POC framework maintains fundamental ethical research principles while aligning with the Netherlands’ regulatory requirements, which are among the most comprehensive player protection measures globally. The following specifications detail how participant protection and engagement are preserved and enhanced:

- 1. **Enhanced Protection Through Regulatory Integration:** The transition to the Netherlands’ stringent regulatory framework provides participants with robust protection that meets or exceeds our original study safeguards. The mandatory

measures, including strict deposit limits and enforced affordability checks, offer more comprehensive controls than our planned tools. Rather than compromising participant protection, this streamlined implementation strengthens safeguards while eliminating potential confusion from overlapping systems.

2. **Communication Protocol Safeguards:** The revised communication framework enhances mandatory notifications with supportive language, ensuring participants receive clear, engaging information about their protection. Rather than maintaining separate risk-based communications, we integrate supportive content into required messages, creating a more cohesive and effective communication approach. This unified strategy prevents message fatigue while maintaining our commitment to transparent communication. Dedicated information resources ensure participants remain well-informed about their comprehensive protections.
3. **Participant Engagement Mechanisms:** Our commitment to participant-driven research remains unchanged through the continuation of qualitative research components. The maintenance of participant interviews and satisfaction surveys, now focused on standardized regulatory tools, ensures players continue as active contributors to research development. This sustained engagement provides valuable insights for future project phases while preserving research inclusivity and participant voice.
4. **Risk Mitigation Protocol:** The framework modifications recognize that participant protection is enhanced, not diminished, by the regulatory transition. Our adapted framework leverages the Netherlands' comprehensive regulatory measures while carefully avoiding any additional complexity or stress. By implementing clear, consistent protective measures and removing redundant interventions, we prevent potential disengagement while ensuring participants receive the highest standard of protection available in online gambling environments.

These specifications ensure the continued prioritization of participant wellbeing, demonstrating how the regulatory framework's stringent requirements complement and enhance our research integrity and participant protection standards.